



Mostly sunny 74/58 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 79/61 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Before he was pope, he was an underdog

Leo didn't start conclave as the front-runner, but he ticked all the boxes

BY ANTHONY FAIOLA, STEFANO PITRELLI AND CHICO HARLAN

VATICAN CITY — Hours before the cardinals, chanting in procession, entered the Sistine Chapel on Wednesday for the start of the conclave, a telling aside occurred inside St. Peter's Basilica. A senior cardinal, seen on camera, offered "good luck" — twice — to the man widely seen as the front-runner to be the next pope: the Italian prelate Pietro Parolin.

But when the white smoke finally appeared Thursday after the fourth vote, it was not Parolin who greeted crowds from the balcony. A cross section of cardinals had coalesced around another, historic choice: Chicago native Robert Prevost, a close ally of Pope Francis who took the name Pope Leo XIV, the first American pontiff.

Cardinal Robert Walter McElroy, the archbishop of Washington, said Prevost's breakthrough occurred Thursday, the day of his selection: "There was a

SEE POPE ON A10

'The real deal for us': The world's Catholics begin to embrace Leo. **A8**

In the U.S.: The new pontiff faces a flock divided along political lines. **A9**



GUADALUPE PARDO/AP

A photo of Pope Leo XIV, center, hangs above one of Pope Francis at the bishop's office in Chiclayo, Peru, on Friday. Leo had led the Diocese of Chiclayo before Francis promoted him in 2023.

Trump cuts' toll on D.C. emerges

RECESSION-LIKE SLIDE SAID TO LOOM

Federal job losses, office vacancies roil region

This article is by Aaron Wiener, Abha Bhattarai, Federica Cocco, Scott Clement and Emily Guskin

The D.C. region's economy is teetering on the edge of a painful slump, experts warn, as the Trump administration's spending cuts, including the elimination of thousands of federal jobs, take their toll on an area that was already struggling to recover from the impacts of the pandemic.

In the city, the number of unemployed residents was up by 12.2 percent in February compared with a year ago, reaching 24,558, even before many of the Trump administration's actions had taken effect, according to the most recent analysis by the D.C. Office of the Chief Financial Officer. New unemployment claims were up 167 percent, to 4,885. Among federal workers, unemployment claims jumped to 285, from just eight in February 2024.

Last month, the bond ratings agency Moody's downgraded the District's rating, stripping it of its coveted triple-A bond rating and probably raising its borrowing costs. The agency cited the Trump administration's "substantial cuts to the federal workforce" and revised D.C.'s outlook to "negative."

Neighboring Prince George's County, in Maryland, is seeing its middle class being hollowed after thousands of federal workers

SEE ECONOMY ON A12

U.S. cracks door for dozens of Afrikaners

White South Africans are an exception to Trump's shutout of refugees

BY TEO ARMUS

Months after the Trump administration ground U.S. refugee admissions to a halt, suspending a program that lets in thousands of people fleeing war or political persecution, it is preparing to restart that effort — but only for one group: White South Africans.

Plans are underway to fly approximately 60 Afrikaners to Dulles International Airport on a State Department-chartered plane Monday, with federal and Virginia officials preparing to receive them in a ceremonial news conference, according to documents and emails obtained by The Washington Post, as well as three government officials familiar with the preparations.

The arriving families, who are part of a group that President Donald Trump has said faces racial discrimination, will then be resettled outside Virginia in 10 states, according to those familiar

SEE AFRIKANERS ON A5

A win for Putin on Russia's Victory Day



ALEXANDER ZEMLIANICHENKO/AP

Servicemen attend Moscow's Victory Day military parade, marking the 80th anniversary of Nazi Germany's defeat.

Russian President Vladimir Putin, joined by two dozen world leaders, defied Western efforts to isolate him. **Story, A6**

DAVID SOUTER 1939-2025

Justice shunned spotlight, favored judicial restraint

Conservatives hoped for a 'home run,' but over two decades he was a reliable vote for the liberal bloc

BY ANN E. MARIMOW

Former Supreme Court justice David Souter, the intellectual New Englander who disappointed Republicans and delighted liberals by slowing a conservative transformation of the high court, died May 8 at his home in New Hampshire. He was 85.

The high court announced his death but did not cite a cause.

Justice Souter, who supplied a key vote to uphold abortion rights in his early years on the court, was a little-known New Hampshire judge dubbed the "stealth candidate" when President George H.W. Bush nominated him in 1990 to replace justice William J. Brennan Jr., then the anchor of an eroding liberal majority.



KEN WILLIAMS/CONCORD MONITOR/AP

David Souter spent much of his career in New Hampshire as judge and attorney general before being named to the Supreme Court.

John H. Sununu, Bush's chief of staff, assured Republicans that the pick would be a "home run for conservatives" who were on the brink of a significant remaking of the court. But the nominee proved to be anything but. His backers in Washington did not realize they were getting someone with a conservative temperament and a dedication to judicial restraint, rather than a conservative ideology.

In nearly two decades on the court, Justice Souter was a reliable vote for the liberal side of the bench in cases involving affirmative action, gay rights, separation of church and state, and restriction of the death penalty. He saw his role as one of quiet resistance against excess and dramatic

SEE SOUTER ON A14

Inflation at McDonald's? Customers are not loving it.

BY HANNAH ZIEGLER

When Nick Martinez and his family wanted a quick, inexpensive and reliable meal, McDonald's used to be their go-to choice.

Now it costs so much, he said, that he lets his 5-year-old son pick from a range of spots near their home in Colton, California, that might have seemed too pricey in the past.

"McDonald's isn't the best value anymore," said Martinez, 50, who has three children. "People are saying, 'Well, if I'm going to pay \$5 for a fry, I'll just go to this place over here.'"

McDonald's latest financial report suggests that sentiment has grown among its traditional customer base. While the company blames its disappointing first-

SEE MCDONALD'S ON A12

IN THE NEWS

ICE moves migrants Detainees are being sent to Texas, where a judge has declined to pause removals under the Alien Enemies Act. **A3**

Airport safety concerns persist Helicopters have continued to fly near National three months after an Army Black Hawk was involved in a deadly collision with a jet. **B1**

THE NATION **Republicans** in Congress fear they'd face repercussions if they approve Medicaid cuts. **A4** **Radar** at Newark's airport briefly stopped working, its second major outage in days. **A5**

THE WORLD **Pakistan** said it had hit several Indian military sites, days after India's strikes in Pakistan. **A7** **A U.S. envoy** to Israel called a Gaza aid plan a Trump initiative, but it lacks participants. **A10**

THE ECONOMY **Tariffs on** Chinese goods are driving up prices and threatening shortages of baby gear in the United States. **A11** **As U.S.-China talks** near, Beijing has been able to defy President Trump's trade pressure thanks to tariff evasion by some exporters. **A13**

THE REGION **In Virginia**, the Democratic gubernatorial nominee said she would not sign a repeal of the right-to-work law. **B1** **Lawmakers** staked out divergent positions on Fox News host Jeanine Pirro, Trump's newly named interim U.S. attorney for D.C. **B1**

STYLE **Carla Hayden**, the first woman and first African American to lead the Library of Congress, was abruptly fired. **C1**

SPORTS **Tom Wilson** "drives the bus" for the Capitals. In Thursday's Game 2 vs. Carolina, he drove it to even the playoff series. **D1**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A11
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A15
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A6

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